

Vishrut Malhotra

Ph.D. Candidate, Ashoka University, Sonipat, Haryana, India

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Education

Ashoka University, Sonipat, Haryana, India

2020 — Summer 2026

Ph.D. Candidate, Department of Economics

(Expected)

Ashoka University, Sonipat, Haryana, India

2017 — 2019

M.A. (Hons.) Economics

University Honours: Cum Laude

University of Delhi, Delhi, India

2013 — 2016

B.A. (Hons.) Economics

Research Interests

Firm Dynamics and Upgrading, International Trade, Structural Transformation, and Innovation

Research Work

Working Papers

Product Quality Upgrading in response to Chinese Competition (Job Market Paper)

Abstract: This paper examines how intensified product market competition from China affects product quality upgrading in Indian manufacturing. Using plant-product level data from India, I infer product quality from price and quantity information following the approach of Khandelwal et al. (2013). For identification, I instrument the growth of Chinese imports into India with the growth in Chinese exports to the rest of the world at the product $\times$ year level, isolating supply-driven variation in Chinese competition. A 10 percent increase in Chinese competition raises product quality by about 1 percent among large Indian plants, with no significant response among smaller plants. The upgrading is robust to controlling for the input-availability channel, an established determinant of quality improvement. Large Indian plants upgrade product quality by increasing investment in fixed capital and incurring a higher share of their production costs on intermediate inputs, as key mechanisms. I further document parallel evidence of quality upgrading in Indian exports at the product $\times$ export-market level using trade data. Export-market quality upgrading is concentrated in products sold to relatively high-income markets. Taken together, the findings indicate that trade-induced competition can act as a catalyst for capital deepening and quality improvement in developing economies, particularly among less-constrained, larger firms.

Product Expansion in Indian Manufacturing

Abstract: This paper examines the role of revenue concentration as a predictor of product addition in multi-product Indian manufacturing firms. Empirical analysis indicates that firms with more concentrated revenue streams are less likely to diversify their product portfolios, holding the number of products constant. To understand this relationship, I develop a dynamic model of heterogeneous firms, where multi-product firms produce differentiated varieties in a general equilibrium setting. The model integrates the dynamic industry framework of Hopenhayn (1992) with the flexible manufacturing environment of Mayer et al. (2014), incorporating two-dimensional firm heterogeneity: core marginal costs and product customisation costs. While core marginal costs evolve over time following an AR(1) process, customisation costs are fixed upon realisation. The model successfully replicates the empirical relationship, demonstrating that firms with higher revenue concentration, despite having higher core productivity, are less likely to diversify due to elevated customisation costs. In contrast, firms with lower revenue concentration exhibit lower core productivity and customisation costs, enabling them to pursue diversification by adding new products

as a primary growth strategy. These findings provide insights into the interplay between firm-level cost structures and expansion strategies of multi-product manufacturing firms in India.

Work in Progress

Trade shock and Product Complexity

Policy

[IGC India Evidence Paper: Firms, trade, and productivity](#)

(with Shruti Bhimsaria and Tim Dobermann)

Conference Talks

Conversation on Research (CoRe), PhD. Colloquium, IGIDR, Mumbai, India 2024

Winter School, Delhi School of Economics, Delhi, India 2024

Teaching Experience

Teaching Fellow, Ashoka University

Graduate level courses

Macroeconomics (Instructor: Dr. Anuradha Saha) Monsoon 2023

Macroeconomics (Instructor: Dr. Pubali Chakraborty) Monsoon 2022

Undergraduate level courses

Introduction to Finance (Instructor: Dr. S.K. Shanthi) Spring 2024

International Finance (Instructor: Dr. Biswajit Banerjee) Spring 2022, 2023

Monetary Theory (Instructor: Dr. Arghya Bhattacharya) Monsoon 2021

Fellowships

Ashoka University

Axis-Ashoka Senior Research Fellowship 2022 — Present

Junior Research Fellowship 2020 — 2022

Work Experience

Centre For Advanced Financial Research And Learning (CAFRAL) 2019 — 2020

Reserve Bank of India, Mumbai, India

Research Associate

Genpact, Enterprise Risk Consulting 2016 — 2017

Gurugram, India

Analyst

Skills

Software and Programming

Stata, Python, Matlab, L^AT_EX

Languages

English (Fluent), Hindi (Native)

References

Devashish Mitra

Professor of Economics,
Gerald B. & Daphna Cramer Professor
of Global Affairs,
The Maxwell School of Citizenship &
Public Affairs,
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